

General Knowledge

Art & Culture

STUDY NOTES

Language and Literature



LANGUAGES AND LITERATURE



Classification of Indian Languages

Indian languages are categorised into several groups based on origin and structure:

1. Indo-Aryan Group

- A branch of the Indo-European family brought to India by the **Aryans**.
- Accounts for around **74% of the population**.
- Divided into:
 - **Old Indo-Aryan Group** (1500 BCE): Origin of **Sanskrit**.
 - **Middle Indo-Aryan Group** (600 BCE - 1000 AD): Includes **Prakrit, Pali**, and **Apabhramsha**.
 - **Modern Indo-Aryan Group** (Post-1000 AD): Includes **Hindi, Bengali, Gujarati, Punjabi, Marathi, Assamese, Urdu**, and others.

2. Dravidian Group

- It is predominantly spoken in **Southern India** and constitutes **25% of the population**.
- Major languages:
 - **Tamil** (Oldest Dravidian language)
 - **Telugu** (Largest Dravidian language)
 - **Kannada**

- **Malayalam**
- Sub-groups:
 - **Northern Dravidian:** Brahui, Malto, Kurukh
 - **Central Dravidian:** Gondi, Kui, Gadaba, Telugu
 - **Southern Dravidian:** Tamil, Kannada, Malayalam, Tulu

3. Sino-Tibetan Group

- Originated from the **Mongoloid family**.
- Spoken across the **Himalayas, North Bengal, Assam, and North-Eastern India**.
- Subgroups:
 - **Tibeto-Burman:** Manipuri, Bhutia, Ladakhi, Abor, Miri, Sherpa
 - **Siamese-Chinese:** Ahom (now extinct)

4. Austric Group

- Also referred to as **Austro-Asiatic** languages.
- Includes **Santhali, Khasi, and Nicobarese**.
- It is spoken mainly in **Central, Eastern, and North-Eastern India**.

5. Others

- Includes **tribal languages** such as Gondi, Oraon, and Praji.

Ancient Languages - Prakrit, Pali, and Apabhramsha

- **Prakrit:** Used in Jain Agamas, associated with the common people.
- **Pali:** Popular in **Magadha** and used for **Buddhist Tripitakas**.
- **Apabhramsha:** Transitional language between **Middle Indo-Aryan** and **Modern Indo-Aryan**.

Classical Languages of India

India's classical languages are recognized for their **antiquity, valuable literary heritage, and unique linguistic traditions**. The government declares a language as **classical** based on certain criteria.

Criteria for Declaring a Language as Classical:

- **Antiquity:** Recorded history of over **1500–2000 years**.
- **Rich Literary Heritage:** Ancient texts and literature deemed **valuable**.
- **Distinct Literary Tradition:** The classical form differs significantly from modern spoken languages.
- **Recognition:** Official promotion by awards and academic research initiatives.

Benefits of Declaring a Language Classical:

- **Two major international awards** for scholars of classical languages.
- Setting up of **academic research centres** dedicated to these languages.
- Financial support for **translation, preservation, and promotion** of literary works.
- **Chairs were established in universities** to promote classical languages.

List of Classical Languages in India:

Language	Year Approved	Region/State	Notable Literature	Special Notes
Tamil	2004	Tamil Nadu, Puducherry, Sri Lanka	Sangam Literature, Thirukkural	One of the oldest Dravidian languages.
Sanskrit	2005	Pan-India	Vedas, Upanishads, Mahabharata, Ramayana	Known as the language of ancient Indian scriptures .
Kannada	2008	Karnataka	Kavirajamarga, Pampa Bharata	Rich in epics and early prose narratives.
Telugu	2008	Andhra Pradesh, Telangana	Andhra Mahabharatam, Kavi Trayam's works	Known for classical poems and folk traditions.
Malayalam	2013	Kerala, Lakshadweep	Ramacharitam, Unnayi Variyar's Nalacharitam	Influential in classical and medieval literature.

Odia	2014	Odisha	Sarala Mahabharata, Charyapada	Known for the earliest recorded inscriptions.
Marathi	2024	Maharashtra	Dnyaneshwari, Tukaram's Abhangas	Strong influence from the Bhakti Movement .
Pali	2024	Pan-India (Buddhist literature)	Tipitaka, Jataka Tales	Language of Theravada Buddhist Canon .
Prakrit	2024	Pan-India (Jain literature)	Gaha Sattasai, Jain Agamas	Used in Jain texts and ancient inscriptions.
Assamese	2024	Assam	Buranjis, Satrir Natya	Influenced by Vaishnavite culture and plays .
Bengali	2024	West Bengal, Bangladesh	Charyapada, Rabindranath Tagore's works	Known for literary movements and poetry .

Ancient Indian Scripts

Script	Period	Region	Language	Special Features
Brahmi	5th-1st century BCE	Pan-India	Prakrit, Sanskrit	Written left to right; earliest known script.
Kharosthi	4th BCE-3rd CE	Gandhara (Pakistan, Afghanistan)	Prakrit	Written right to left; used in Ashokan edicts.
Gupta	4th-6th century CE	North India	Sanskrit	Evolved into Nagari and Bengali scripts.
Nagari (Devanagari)	7th century CE onwards	North and Central India	Sanskrit, Hindi, Marathi	Used for religious texts like Vedas and Puranas.

Tamil-Brahmi	3rd BCE–6th CE	Tamil Nadu	Early Tamil	Found in cave inscriptions and pottery.
Grantha	6th–12th century CE	Tamil Nadu	Sanskrit	Used for writing Vedic texts in South India.
Sharada	8th century CE onwards	Kashmir	Sanskrit, Kashmiri	Used for manuscripts in Kashmir.
Siddham	6th–12th century CE	North India	Sanskrit	Influenced Tibetan and Japanese scripts.
Proto-Sinhalese	3rd century BCE	Sri Lanka	Early Sinhalese	Derived from Southern Brahmi.

Importance of Ancient Scripts in Indian Culture

- **Preservation of Knowledge:** Scripts were essential for writing **religious texts**, administrative records, and literary works.
- **Cultural Exchange:** The diffusion of Indian scripts influenced **Southeast Asian and Tibetan writing systems**.
- **Religious Significance:** Texts inscribed in these scripts served as mediums for transmitting **Buddhism, Jainism, and Hinduism**.
- **Archaeological Importance:** **Inscriptions and coins** written in ancient scripts help historians **decipher India's past**.

Indian Literature

1. Vedic Literature

Book Name	Language	Author	Year	Feature
Rigveda	Sanskrit	Rishis	~1500 BCE	Collection of Hymns
Samaveda	Sanskrit	Unknown	~1200 BCE	Focuses on musical chants

Yajurveda	Sanskrit	Unknown	~1200 BCE	Ritual instructions
Atharvaveda	Sanskrit	Unknown	~1000 BCE	Spells, charms, prayers
Brahmanas	Sanskrit	Unknown	~900 BCE	Ritual explanations
Aranyakas	Sanskrit	Unknown	~700 BCE	Forest treatises
Upanishads	Sanskrit	Unknown	~800 BCE	Philosophical treatises
Aitareya Brahmana	Sanskrit	Unknown	~800 BCE	Part of Rigveda Brahmana
Shatapatha Brahmana	Sanskrit	Unknown	~800 BCE	Explains Yajurveda
Taittiriya Upanishad	Sanskrit	Unknown	~700 BCE	Philosophical text
Chandogya Upanishad	Sanskrit	Unknown	~700 BCE	Philosophical discussions
Brihadaranyaka	Sanskrit	Yajnavalkya	~700 BCE	Oldest Upanishad
Mundaka Upanishad	Sanskrit	Unknown	~600 BCE	Concept of knowledge
Kena Upanishad	Sanskrit	Unknown	~600 BCE	Explores mind and spirit
Isha Upanishad	Sanskrit	Unknown	~600 BCE	Focus on self-realization
Prashna Upanishad	Sanskrit	Unknown	~600 BCE	Philosophical questions
Shvetashvatara	Sanskrit	Unknown	~600 BCE	Focuses on theism

2. Epic Literature

Book Name	Language	Author	Year	Feature
Mahabharata	Sanskrit	Vyasa	~400 BCE	The longest epic, the Bhagavad Gita included

Ramayana	Sanskrit	Valmiki	~500 BCE	Epic of Lord Rama
Harivamsa	Sanskrit	Vyasa	~300 CE	Supplement to Mahabharata
Bhagavad Gita	Sanskrit	Vyasa	~400 BCE	Philosophical dialogue
Ramacharitmanas	Awadhi	Tulsidas	1574 CE	Retelling of Ramayana
Shishupala Vadha	Sanskrit	Magha	~7th CE	Story of Shishupala's death
Kiratarjuniya	Sanskrit	Bharavi	~6th CE	Arjuna's encounter with Shiva
Dashakumaracharita	Sanskrit	Dandin	~7th CE	Adventure stories of ten princes
Uttararama Charita	Sanskrit	Bhavabhuti	~8th CE	Sequel to Ramayana
Raghuvamsa	Sanskrit	Kalidasa	~4th CE	Epic on the Raghu dynasty
Ananda Ramayana	Sanskrit	Unknown	~15th CE	Later addition to the Ramayana tradition
Ashvaghosha's Buddhacharita	Sanskrit	Ashvaghosha	~2nd CE	Life of Buddha
Jaimini Bharata	Kannada	Jaimini	~13th CE	Mahabharata retelling
Bhasa's plays	Sanskrit	Bhasa	~3rd CE	Early Sanskrit dramas
Kumarasambhavam	Sanskrit	Kalidasa	~4th CE	Story of Shiva and Parvati
Narayaneeyam	Sanskrit	Melpathur Narayana Bhattathiri	~16th CE	Devotional text on Vishnu

Tamil Kamban Ramayana	Tamil	Kambar	~12th CE	Tamil retelling of Ramayana
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3. Classical Sanskrit Literature

Book Name	Language	Author	Year	Feature
Abhijnanasakuntalam	Sanskrit	Kalidasa	~4th CE	Story of Shakuntala
Meghaduta	Sanskrit	Kalidasa	~4th CE	Lyric poem
Mudrarakshasa	Sanskrit	Vishakhadatta	~4th CE	Political drama
Malavikagnimitram	Sanskrit	Kalidasa	~4th CE	Love story play
Ratnavali	Sanskrit	Harsha	~7th CE	Court drama
Nagananda	Sanskrit	Harsha	~7th CE	Buddhist-themed drama
Kamasutra	Sanskrit	Vatsyayana	~2nd CE	Treatise on love
Arthashastra	Sanskrit	Kautilya	~3rd BCE	Political treatise
Ashtadhyayi	Sanskrit	Panini	~5th BCE	Work on grammar
Bhattikavya	Sanskrit	Bhatti	~7th CE	Poetic grammar
Sutralankara	Sanskrit	Ashvaghosha	~2nd CE	Treatise on poetics
Amarakosha	Sanskrit	Amarasimha	~4th CE	Lexicon
Charaka Samhita	Sanskrit	Charaka	~2nd CE	Medical text
Sushruta Samhita	Sanskrit	Sushruta	~6th BCE	Surgery text
Ritusamhara	Sanskrit	Kalidasa	~4th CE	Poem on seasons
Hitopadesha	Sanskrit	Narayana	~9th CE	Fables collection

Panchatantra	Sanskrit	Vishnu Sharma	~3rd BCE	Animal fables
Kadambari	Sanskrit	Banabhatta	~7th CE	Prose romance

4. Pali and Prakrit Literature

Book Name	Language	Author	Year	Feature
Tripitaka	Pali	Unknown	~3rd BCE	Buddhist scripture
Dhammapada	Pali	Unknown	~3rd BCE	Buddhist teachings
Mahavastu	Prakrit	Unknown	~2nd BCE	Buddhist legends
Divyavadana	Prakrit	Unknown	~2nd CE	Buddhist fables
Gathasaptashati	Prakrit	Hala	~2nd CE	Love Poems
Jain Agamas	Prakrit	Various Jain Acharyas	~2nd CE	Jain scripture
Sutrakritanga	Prakrit	Jain Acharyas	~2nd CE	Jain philosophy
Bhagavati Sutra	Prakrit	Jain Scholars	~1st CE	Jain cosmology

5. Tamil Sangam Literature

Book Name	Language	Author	Year	Feature
Thirukkural	Tamil	Thiruvalluvar	~1st BCE	Ethical couplets
Silappatikaram	Tamil	Ilango Adigal	~2nd CE	Epic on Kannagi
Manimekalai	Tamil	Sathanar	~2nd CE	Buddhist themes
Akananuru	Tamil	Various	~2nd BCE	Love poetry
Purananuru	Tamil	Various	~2nd BCE	War poems

Medieval Indian Literature

- **Persian Literature:**

- Introduced to India during the **12th century** with the arrival of **Turks** and Mongols.
- Persian became the **language of administration** and the court.
- Many Persian poets and historians flourished, contributing to Indian literature.

- **Urdu Literature:**

- Evolved with Persian influence but followed **Hindi grammar** with the **Persian script**.
- Urdu became a popular literary language, merging local dialects with Persian expressions.

- **Prominent Works and Authors:**

- **Amir Khusrau:** One of the finest Persian poets, known for his *Diwan* (collection of Persian poetry).
- **Zia-ud-din Barani:** Wrote *Tarikh-e-Firuz Shahi*, a significant historical account.
- **Babur:** Authored *Tuzuk-i-Babari* in **Turkish**, detailing his reign.
- **Jahangir:** Wrote *Tuzuk-i-Jahangiri* about his life and governance.
- **Abul Fazl:** Created *Akbarnama*, a historical chronicle of Emperor Akbar's reign.
- **Malik Muhammad Jayasi:** Wrote *Padmavat* in **Awadhi**, blending romance and spirituality.
- **Iqbal:** A major 20th-century Urdu poet, wrote *Bang-i-Dara* and the famous national song *Saare Jahan Se Achcha*.

Important Books from the Medieval Period

Book Name	Language	Author	Year	Feature
Diwan	Persian	Amir Khusrau	~13th CE	Collection of poetry
Tarikh-e-Firuz Shahi	Persian	Zia-ud-din Barani	~14th CE	Historical chronicle
Tuzuk-i-Babari	Turkish	Babur	~16th CE	Babur's autobiography
Tuzuk-i-Jahangiri	Persian	Jahangir	~17th CE	Jahangir's memoirs

Akbarnama	Persian	Abul Fazl	~16th CE	History of Akbar's reign
Padmavat	Awadhi	Malik Muhammad Jayasi	~1540 CE	Romantic epic
Miftah-ul-Futuh	Persian	Amir Khusrau	~13th CE	Chronicle of victories
Khazain-ul-Futuh	Persian	Amir Khusrau	~14th CE	Historical account
Tabaqat-i-Nasiri	Persian	Minhaj-i-Siraj	~13th CE	History of early Muslim rulers
Futuh-us-Salatin	Persian	Isami	~14th CE	Account of Muslim conquests
Laila Majnun	Persian	Amir Khusrau	~13th CE	Romantic poem
Shahnama	Persian	Ferdowsi	~10th CE	Epic of Persian kings
Babar Nama	Turkish	Babur	~16th CE	Alternate autobiography
Gulistan	Persian	Saadi	~13th CE	Persian prose fables
Masnavi	Persian	Rumi	~13th CE	Spiritual poetry
Chachnama	Persian	Ali Kufi	~13th CE	History of Sindh's conquest
Tarikh-i-Yamini	Persian	Utbi	~11th CE	History of Mahmud of Ghazni
Kitab-ul-Hind	Arabic	Al-Biruni	~11th CE	Study of India
Fawa'id-ul-Fuad	Persian	Amir Hasan Sijzi	~13th CE	Conversations of Nizamuddin Auliya
Rihla	Arabic	Ibn Battuta	~14th CE	Travelogue

Tarikh-i-Alai	Persian	Amir Khusrau	~13th CE	Account of Alauddin Khalji's reign
Iqbalnama	Persian	Abul Fazl	~16th CE	Biography of Akbar
Ajaib-ul-Hind	Persian	Ibn Battuta	~14th CE	Wonders of India
Bustan	Persian	Saadi	~13th CE	Prose fable collection
Rubaiyat	Persian	Omar Khayyam	~11th CE	Philosophical quatrains
Mirat-i-Sikandari	Persian	Sikandar	~17th CE	Gujarat's history
Sirr-i-Akbar	Persian	Dara Shikoh	~17th CE	Translation of Upanishads
Shahjahan Nama	Persian	Inayat Khan	~17th CE	Chronicle of Shah Jahan's reign
Zafarnama	Persian	Guru Gobind Singh	~17th CE	Letter to Aurangzeb
Bang-i-Dara	Urdu	Iqbal	~20th CE	Poetry collection
Saare Jahan Se Achcha	Urdu	Iqbal	~20th CE	Patriotic song
Risala-i-Haq Numa	Persian	Muhammad Ghawth	~16th CE	Sufi text
Baharistan	Persian	Jami	~15th CE	Literary collection
Miftah-ul-Arifin	Persian	Shah Waliullah	~18th CE	Mystical text
Tarikh-i-Akbari	Persian	Arif Qandahari	~16th CE	Akbar's history

Tarikh-i-Mubarak Shahi	Persian	Yahya bin Ahmad Sirhindi	~15th CE	History of Delhi Sultanate
Rozat-us-Safa	Persian	Mir Khwand	~15th CE	History of Islam
Lubb-al-Lubab	Persian	Abul Fazl	~16th CE	Historical summary
Masnavi-i-Khusrau	Persian	Amir Khusrau	~13th CE	Mystical poetry
Tarikh-i-Muhammadi	Persian	Muhammad Bihamadkhani	~15th CE	History of Muhammad Ghor
Bustan-i-Firdausi	Persian	Firdausi	~10th CE	Epic poetry
Tarikh-i-Masumi	Persian	Masum Bhakkari	~17th CE	History of Sindh
Mirat-i-Ahmadi	Persian	Ali Muhammad Khan	~18th CE	History of Gujarat

Modern Indian Literature (19th–20th Century)

Modern Indian literature reflects the impact of British colonial rule, the rise of nationalism, and the socio-political changes across the subcontinent. The literature from this period evolved in both **regional languages** and **English**, and new genres such as novels, short stories, essays, and dramas became prevalent.

- **Themes:** Nationalism, social reform, identity, caste issues, independence struggle, and individualism.
- **Languages:** Bengali, Hindi, Urdu, English, Marathi, Kannada, Malayalam, Gujarati, Tamil, and Telugu.
- **Key Movements:** Progressive Writers' Movement, Indian Renaissance, and Post-Independence literature.

Key Writers and Trends

- **Rabindranath Tagore:** Nobel Laureate in Literature (1913) for *Gitanjali*; known for his poetry, novels, and plays.
- **Munshi Premchand:** a Pioneer of Hindi and Urdu fiction; highlighted social issues through novels like *Godaan* and *Nirmala*.
- **Bankim Chandra Chatterjee:** Wrote *Anandamath*, which contains the patriotic song *Vande Mataram*.
- **Sarojini Naidu:** Known as the "Nightingale of India," wrote *The Broken Wing* and nationalist poetry.
- **R. K. Narayan:** Created the fictional town of Malgudi in works like *The Guide* and *Malgudi Days*.
- **Mulk Raj Anand:** Addressed caste discrimination in *Untouchable* and *Coolie*.
- **Salman Rushdie:** Known for *Midnight's Children*, which won the Booker Prize in 1981.
- **Arundhati Roy:** Won the Booker Prize for *The God of Small Things* in 1997.
- **Ismat Chughtai:** Urdu writer known for her bold and controversial themes in *Lihaaf*.
- **Iqbal:** Wrote Urdu poetry, including *Sare Jahan Se Achha*.

Table of Important Books from the Modern Period

Book Name	Language	Author	Year	Feature
Gitanjali	Bengali	Rabindranath Tagore	1910	Won Nobel Prize in 1913
Godaan	Hindi	Munshi Premchand	1936	Peasant life novel
Anandamath	Bengali	Bankim Chandra Chatterjee	1882	Contains <i>Vande Mataram</i>
Chokher Bali	Bengali	Rabindranath Tagore	1903	Explores human emotions
Ghare Baire	Bengali	Rabindranath Tagore	1916	Novel on nationalism
Malgudi Days	English	R. K. Narayan	1943	Short story collection
The Guide	English	R. K. Narayan	1958	Booker-nominated novel

Untouchable	English	Mulk Raj Anand	1935	Deals with caste discrimination
Coolie	English	Mulk Raj Anand	1936	Story of labor exploitation
The Broken Wing	English	Sarojini Naidu	1917	Poetry collection
Midnight's Children	English	Salman Rushdie	1981	Booker Prize winner
The God of Small Things	English	Arundhati Roy	1997	Booker Prize winner
Lihaaf	Urdu	Ismat Chughtai	1942	Bold short story
Bang-i-Dara	Urdu	Allama Iqbal	1924	Poetry collection
Sare Jahan Se Achha	Urdu	Allama Iqbal	1904	Patriotic song
Tamas	Hindi	Bhisham Sahni	1974	Partition novel
Pinjar	Punjabi	Amrita Pritam	1950	Novel on partition
A Passage to India	English	E. M. Forster	1924	Explores British-Indian tensions
Train to Pakistan	English	Khushwant Singh	1956	Partition narrative
Kanthapura	English	Raja Rao	1938	Gandhian themes
Nirmala	Hindi	Munshi Premchand	1928	Explores child marriage
Yashodhara	Marathi	Sumitranandan Pant	1930	Poetic narrative
Kalyani	Hindi	Subhadra Kumari Chauhan	1936	Story of social reform

Andha Yug	Hindi	Dharamvir Bharati	1953	Play set in Mahabharata era
Samskara	Kannada	U. R. Ananthamurthy	1965	Critique of caste
Pather Panchali	Bengali	Bibhutibhushan Bandopadhyay	1929	Inspired Satyajit Ray's film
Char Adhyay	Bengali	Rabindranath Tagore	1934	Novel on revolution
The Inheritance of Loss	English	Kiran Desai	2006	Booker Prize winner
The White Tiger	English	Aravind Adiga	2008	Booker Prize winner
Gora	Bengali	Rabindranath Tagore	1910	Explores identity and nationalism
Bhuli Hui Raaste	Hindi	Harivansh Rai Bachchan	1968	Poetry collection
Kamayani	Hindi	Jaishankar Prasad	1936	Epic poem
Shrikant	Bengali	Sarat Chandra Chattopadhyay	1917	Social reform novel
Devdas	Bengali	Sarat Chandra Chattopadhyay	1917	Tragic love story
Rajmohan's Wife	English	Bankim Chandra Chatterjee	1864	First Indian novel in English
Hazaar Chaurasi Ki Maa	Hindi	Mahasweta Devi	1974	Naxalite movement novel
Jhootan	Hindi	Om Prakash Valmiki	1997	Dalit autobiography
Kafan	Hindi	Munshi Premchand	1936	Short story on poverty

The Home and the World	Bengali	Rabindranath Tagore	1916	Story of nationalism
Aparajito	Bengali	Bibhutibhushan Bandopadhyay	1932	Sequel to <i>Pather Panchali</i>
Chitra	Bengali	Rabindranath Tagore	1892	Dance drama
Kabuliwala	Bengali	Rabindranath Tagore	1892	Story of friendship
Mrinalini	Bengali	Bankim Chandra Chatterjee	1869	Historical romance
Parineeta	Bengali	Sarat Chandra Chattopadhyay	1914	Romantic novella
Raag Darbari	Hindi	Shrilal Shukla	1968	Satirical novel
The Last Mughal	English	William Dalrymple	2006	History of Mughal decline
English, August	English	Upamanyu Chatterjee	1988	Satirical novel
A Fine Balance	English	Rohinton Mistry	1995	Story of India's emergency period
Sea of Poppies	English	Amitav Ghosh	2008	Historical fiction
Shadow Lines	English	Amitav Ghosh	1988	Partition narrative